

Cause Web Teacher Notes

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 30-40 min

Category	History	Time	30-40 min
Difficulty	Medium	ID	cause-web

Big idea: Causation is layered and contestable.

Overview

Students investigate complex causation in historical explanation.

Student Prompt

Inspect Cause Web Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Cause Web Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Cause Web Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Cards sorted into trigger, background condition, actor, and consequence. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Cause Web Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A debate over whether one cause can be 'the' cause. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Causation is layered and contestable.

Actual Lesson Questions and Key

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Cause Web Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Cause Web Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	How do historians decide which causes matter most?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how causation is layered and contestable.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Ready-to-Use Examples

- A web of causes for a school rule change, historical event, or social movement.
- Cards sorted into trigger, background condition, actor, and consequence.
- A debate over whether one cause can be 'the' cause.

Suggested Timing

Stage	Teacher move	Watch for
1	Students create a web of causes.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
2	They label causes as long-term, short-term, structural, individual, accidental or ideological.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
3	They choose the three most important causes and justify their ranking.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
4	Groups compare rankings.	Assumptions, confidence shifts, evidence claims, and language choices.
Debrief	Move from the activity result to a TOK knowledge question.	Students distinguishing method, evidence, interpretation, and overclaiming.

Teacher Language

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Common Misconceptions

- Students may treat sources as transparent windows rather than selected traces.
- Students may confuse explaining context with excusing actions.

Assessment Look-Fors

- Uses source evidence while naming selection, silence, and perspective.
- Distinguishes historical claim, interpretation, and judgement.

Differentiation and Adaptations

- Short lesson: use only the first example, one response grid, and one debrief question.
- Long lesson: add a second round where students revise the method and compare outcomes.
- Low-tech option: run with printed cards, sticky notes, and a board tally.

Extension Tasks

- Design a second version of the activity that tests the same knowledge issue in another AOK.
- Find a real-world example where the same knowledge problem matters outside the classroom.
- Write a 150-word TOK exhibition-style commentary using the activity as the object context.

Related Activities

- Broken Archive
- Same Event, Different Historian
- Presentism Trial